

TACKLING Pakistan

Neutralising Pakistan requires pressure on multiple fronts. The buzz is 'smart' strategy.

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Those who cannot remember the past are condemned to repeat it—George Santayana

History has a tendency of repeating itself in relations between India and Pakistan—too often for comfort. In just 16 years, the two countries have had five major confrontations, including the one developing over Mumbai 26/11. These have either brought them close to war or resulted in a sharp border conflict as in Kargil.

The core issue had been Kashmir for many years and, more recently, because of the spread of Islamic fundamentalism it has taken on religious undertones too. Kashmir, in many ways, had become a proxy for the larger ideological battle that resulted in the Partition. The Indian nation with its secular, democratic foundation has always been anathema to a Pakistan that projects itself as an Islamic Republic.

More so recently when India with its phenomenal GDP growth had emerged as a major power in the region with

even the US wanting an enhanced strategic relationship with it. In sharp contrast, Pakistan's economy is in shambles, it is riven with internal dissent and sectarian warfare and is a haven for Islamic terror groups. The Pakistan Army, which directly ruled the country through dictatorships for more than half of its 61 years of existence, was being reviled by its own populace.

Meanwhile, the US had stepped up pressure to fight an unpopular war in the Afghan front to subdue the Taliban. It was viewed by the Pakistan's people as an American war against their Islamist brethren. For the first time in its history the Pakistan Army had desertions from its ranks.

Mumbai 26/11 was an assertion of the Pakistan Army's new game plan to grab centre-stage and restore its supremacy. Targeting India is a tried and tested way for the Pakistan Army. It launched its "war of thousand cuts" to bleed India in 1990, the year it acquired nuclear weapons capability. That development saw



India's overwhelming superiority in conventional warfare being nullified and the confidence that a full-scale war is almost ruled out as it was certain to take on nuclear dimensions. So Pakistan began its low intensity warfare that did enough to hurt India but not enough for Delhi to declare war.

When targeting Kashmir alone didn't have the desired impact, the terror strikes moved to the rest of India where it not only attacked religious shrines but also hit at its economic interests. As Prime Minister Manmohan Singh pointed out recently, "Pakistan has utilised terror as an instrument of state policy."

Mumbai 26/11 is now increasingly being seen as a diabolical plan of the Pakistan Army which served several ends. If India ratcheted the war

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INDIA CAN MOUNT SUSTAINED INTERNATIONAL PRESSURE
ON PAKISTAN TO EXTRADITE THE MUMBAI MASTERMINDS